ACADEMIC EXCHANGE FORUM

Principles of Leadership — Simplified Notes

BCPC 305 | All weeks, explained in plain language, with a quick test after each week

---

This is the full semester's lecture content rewritten in plain language, organised week by week exactly as taught, with a short test at the end of each week so you can check yourself before moving on. Weeks 8 (Mid-Semester Exam) and 12 (Revision) introduce no new content, so they're not included here — use this document itself to revise for both.

Contents

• Week 1 — Foundations of Leadership

• Week 2 — Theories of Leadership

• Week 3 — Contingency Theories of Leadership

• Week 4 — Leadership in Practice & Governance

• Week 5 — Trust and Power in Leadership

• Week 6 — Traditional Leadership

• Week 7 — Leadership Styles and Skills

• Week 9 — Decision-Making Models and Styles

• Week 10 — Leading Teams and Crisis Management

• Week 11 — Ethical Leadership and Values

Week 1 — Foundations of Leadership

The starting names — Gandhi, Mother Theresa, Martin Luther King, Mandela, Nkrumah, but also Hitler — make a deliberate point: leadership is simply the *ability to influence people toward a goal*. History shows that ability can be used well or badly; it isn't automatically virtuous.

What is leadership?

In plain terms: **leadership is the process of influencing a group of people toward a shared goal.** Northouse (2004) shifted the focus from "personality" to "process" — leadership is something that happens between people, not a fixed trait one person has. Four things almost every definition agrees on (Northouse, 2001): process, influence, group context, goal attainment. It's a two-way, multidirectional relationship — followers influence leaders too — and it should produce real, constructive change.

The four levels of leadership

Personal — leading yourself through self-discipline and example. **Group (Direct)** — coordinating and motivating a team toward a shared goal. **Organisational (Managerial)** — harmonising a whole organisation, requiring Technical, Social, Conceptual, and Spiritual competence. **Strategic** — creating value and opportunity that outlasts the leader, following a process of strategic thinking, selling the vision, planning, implementation, and review.

What leadership actually does (its functions)

Inspire a shared vision; develop followers into self-leaders; drive constructive change; solve problems and mediate conflict; and harness the resources needed to actually achieve the vision — a vision without resources is just a wish.

Leadership vs. Management

The most exam-favoured distinction in Week 1. Management is a career; leadership is a calling. Managers must be obeyed because of their position; leaders are followed because people want to. **Management = doing things right (efficiency). Leadership = doing the right things (effectiveness).** Managers administer, maintain, and ask "how and when"; leaders innovate, inspire, and ask "what and why." In real jobs the two overlap constantly.

Quick Test — Week Recap

1. What four elements does almost every definition of leadership agree on?

   Answer: Process, influence, group context, and goal attainment (Northouse, 2001).

2. Name the four levels of leadership.

   Answer: Personal, Group (Direct), Organisational (Managerial), and Strategic.

3. Fill in: Management is doing things ___; leadership is doing the ___ things.

   Answer: Right; right — i.e. "doing things right" (management) vs. "doing the right things" (leadership).

4. Why does leadership need to produce constructive change to really count as leadership?

   Answer: Because leadership is about moving a group toward a goal — if nothing changes, no real influence toward that goal has actually taken place.

Week 2 — Theories of Leadership

Great Man Theory

The oldest view: leaders are born with natural leadership ability, not made through training. It's largely been superseded, but it's the historical starting point for every theory that followed.

Trait Theory

Looks for a consistent set of personal traits (confidence, intelligence, determination) that separate leaders from everyone else. Stogdill's 1948 study is the classic criticism: he found no single set of traits held up consistently across different situations — which is exactly what opened the door to later, more situational theories.

The Managerial Grid (Blake & Mouton, 1964)

Plots leaders on two axes — concern for people and concern for production, each 1 to 9 — giving five named styles. **(9,1) Task/Authority-Compliance** — high production, low people focus. **(1,9) Country Club** — comfortable, relationship-focused, often at the cost of output. **(1,1) Impoverished** — low on both; minimal effort either way. **(5,5) Middle-of-the-Road** — a balanced but uninspired compromise. **(9,9) Team/Sound Management** — the ideal: high on both people and production.

The Pygmalion and Golem Effects

Two mirror-image self-fulfilling prophecies. The **Pygmalion Effect**: high expectations from a leader genuinely help people perform better. The **Golem Effect**: the opposite — low expectations or visible doubt actually make people perform worse.

Quick Test — Week Recap

1. What did Stogdill's 1948 study find, and why does it matter?

Answer: That no consistent set of traits separated leaders from non-leaders across situations — a core criticism that helped move leadership theory beyond pure Trait Theory.

2. Which Managerial Grid style is considered most effective, and why?

Answer: (9,9) Team Management — because it combines high concern for people with high concern for production, rather than trading one off against the other.

3. What's the difference between the Pygmalion and Golem effects?

Answer: Pygmalion: high expectations improve performance. Golem: low expectations or doubt make performance worse — they're opposite sides of the same self-fulfilling-prophecy coin.

Week 3 — Contingency Theories of Leadership

The core idea across all three theories this week: **there is no one best leadership style — effectiveness depends on the situation.**

Fiedler's Contingency Theory (1967)

Fiedler assumed a leader's style is fixed, measured by the Least-Preferred Co-worker (LPC) scale — a high score means relationship-oriented, a low score means task-oriented. Three situational factors determine how favourable a situation is: leader-member relations, task structure, and position power. Task-oriented (low LPC) leaders do best in very favourable or very unfavourable situations; relationship-oriented (high LPC) leaders do best in the moderate middle ground. Since style is fixed, Fiedler's fix for a bad match is to change the leader, not the style.

Hersey and Blanchard's Situational Leadership Theory (1969)

Unlike Fiedler, this theory says leaders *should* adapt their style to the follower's readiness level (D1 to D4 — how able and willing they are). Four matching styles: **S1 Telling** (D1, unable and unwilling — give clear instructions), **S2 Selling** (D2, unable but willing — direction plus encouragement), **S3 Participating** (D3, able but unwilling — involve and motivate), **S4 Delegating** (D4, able and willing — step back and hand over responsibility).

Path-Goal Theory (House, 1971)

Built on Expectancy Theory (motivation = expectancy × instrumentality × valence). The leader's job is to clarify the path to followers' goals and remove obstacles. Four styles: **Directive** (clear instructions, for ambiguous tasks or inexperienced followers), **Supportive** (emotional support, for stressful tasks), **Participative** (consult followers, for experienced/creative tasks), **Achievement-oriented** (set challenging goals, for competent, motivated followers). Followers with an internal locus of control ("my effort decides the outcome") tend to prefer participative leadership; those with an external locus prefer directive leadership.

Quick Test — Week Recap

1. What single idea unites Fiedler, Hersey-Blanchard, and Path-Goal theory?

   Answer: That leadership effectiveness depends on the situation — there's no single best style that works everywhere.

2. How does Fiedler's view of leadership style differ from Hersey and Blanchard's?

   Answer: Fiedler treats style as fixed (so you change the leader to fit the situation); Hersey and Blanchard expect the same leader to adapt their style to the follower's readiness level.

3. Which Path-Goal style fits a follower who is competent, motivated, and ready for a challenge?

   Answer: Achievement-oriented leadership.

Week 4 — Leadership in Practice & Governance

The 5 Practices of Exemplary Leadership (Kouzes & Posner)

Built from real stories of peak leadership experiences, this model focuses on observable behaviour, not personality: **Model the Way** (lead by example), **Inspire a Shared Vision** (paint a picture of the future people want to reach), **Challenge the Process** (search out ways to improve, take risks), **Enable Others to Act** (build trust and collaboration), **Encourage the Heart** (recognise people's contributions so the hard work feels worth it).

Leadership development areas

Decision-making, communication, emotional intelligence (EQ), conflict resolution, adaptability, and strategic thinking — all treated as skills to be developed over a leader's lifetime, not fixed traits.

Leadership and governance

Governance is how power is exercised in managing a country's resources. Effective leadership in governance rests on five principles: **Promotes Stability**, **Ensures Accountability**, **Enhances Responsiveness**, **Encourages Participation**, and **Supports Ethical Governance**. Where leadership fails, the consequences are predictable: instability, corruption, public distrust, and policy failure.

Leadership and organisational culture

Common culture types: **Hierarchical** (strict chain of command), **Collegial** (teamwork and open communication), **Entrepreneurial** (innovation and risk-taking), **Clan** (family-like loyalty), **Results-oriented** (competition, measurable targets), **Customer-centric** (service comes first).

Quick Test — Week Recap

1. Name any three of the 5 Practices of Exemplary Leadership.

Answer: Any three of: Model the Way, Inspire a Shared Vision, Challenge the Process, Enable Others to Act, Encourage the Heart.

2. What does "Ensures Accountability" mean as a governance principle?

Answer: Leaders hold themselves and their teams responsible for outcomes, which builds public trust.

3. Which organisational culture type is defined by competition and measurable outcomes?

Answer: Results-oriented culture.

Week 5 — Trust and Power in Leadership

What is trust?

Mayer et al. (1995): trust is an emotional and psychological belief in the goodness, strength, or truth of another person. In leadership, trust must be *earned* — a common mistake is assuming a title automatically grants it. Dimensions of trust: Integrity, Competence, Consistency, Loyalty, Openness. Types of trust: **Competence** trust (they can get it done), **Benevolence** trust (they mean well by you), **Integrity** trust (they act on principle regardless of who's watching).

Building and maintaining trust

Clarity, compassion, character, contribution, competency, connection, commitment, and consistency — the lecture frames trust as built from small, repeated actions over time, not one big gesture. What undermines it: self-orientation, lack of transparency, inconsistency, and ethical breaches.

The concept and sources of power

Power is the capacity to influence others (Yukl, 2006). Seven sources: Position, Charisma, Relationship, Information, Expertise, Punishment, Reward.

Types of power

French and Raven (1959) identified five: **Legitimate** (formal position), **Reward** (ability to reward), **Coercive** (ability to punish), **Expert** (specialised knowledge), **Referent** (admiration and charisma). Hershey and Blanchard (1982) added two more: **Connection** (networking) and **Information** (access to valuable knowledge). These seven split into two groups: *positional* power (legitimate, reward, coercive — tied to the role) and *personal* power (expert, referent, connection, information — tied to the individual).

Quick Test — Week Recap

1. What's the difference between Competence trust and Benevolence trust?

Answer: Competence trust is about ability — you trust them to get the job done. Benevolence trust is about intentions — you trust they have your best interests at heart.

2. Name two of French and Raven's original five types of power.

Answer: Any two of: Legitimate, Reward, Coercive, Expert, Referent.

3. Which two types of power did Hershey and Blanchard add, and are they positional or personal?

Answer: Connection and Information — both are personal power, tied to the individual rather than their formal role.

4. Give one factor that undermines trust in leadership.

Answer: Any one of: self-orientation, lack of transparency, inconsistency, ethical breaches.

Week 6 — Traditional Leadership

Defining traditional leadership

Under Article 277 of the 1992 Constitution, a traditional leader (chief) is someone who hails from the appropriate family/lineage and is validly nominated, elected, or selected and enstooled, enskinned, or installed under customary law. The National House of Chiefs (NHC) is the institution responsible for traditional matters — Ghana has more than 32,000 chiefs (Dzivenu, 2011).

Before colonialism: two systems

Centralised authority — a clear hierarchy with a King or Paramount Chief at the top. **Decentralised (acephalous) systems** — the family head was the rallying point of authority instead. Both were formally recognised through the colonial era and into successive constitutions.

Constitutional architecture

Article 270 recognises chieftaincy under customary law. Article 271 requires each region to select five Paramount Chiefs. Article 273 gives the NHC appellate jurisdiction over chieftaincy disputes, with a Judicial Committee assisted by a lawyer recommended by the Attorney-General. Article 274 requires each region to establish its own Regional House of Chiefs. Article 275 disqualifies anyone convicted of high treason, fraud, dishonesty, or immorality from being a chief — and chiefs may not take part in active party politics.

Roles of chiefs

Historically Political, Social, and Military — the British added a Judicial role once they recognised chiefs' competence and influence, leading to indirect rule. Today's debate: should chieftaincy modernise toward democracy, or should democracy make room for tradition? Newer forms include Development Chiefs, Youth Chiefs, Non-titled Chiefs, and Migrant Chiefs.

Quick Test — Week Recap

1. What two forms of traditional authority existed in Ghana before colonialism?

Answer: Centralised authority (a King/Paramount Chief at the top) and decentralised (acephalous) systems, where the family head held authority.

2. What disqualifies someone from being a chief under Article 275?

Answer: Conviction for high treason, high crime, or offences involving state security, fraud, dishonesty, or immorality.

3. What are the four roles chiefs have historically played in Ghana?

Answer: Political, Social, Military, and (added later, under British influence) Judicial.

Week 7 — Leadership Styles and Skills

The three classic leadership styles (Lewin, 1939)

Authoritarian (Autocratic) — clear expectations, decisions made independently; best where time is short or the leader is most knowledgeable, but can be seen as controlling. **Participative (Democratic)** — the leader guides but invites input; Lewin found this the most effective style overall. **Laissez-Faire (Delegative)** — little or no guidance; research found this the least productive of the three, often leading to poorly defined roles.

Transformational vs. Transactional leadership

Transformational leadership (Bass, 1985) inspires higher motives and a shared vision, via four elements: idealised influence, inspirational motivation, intellectual stimulation, and individual consideration. **Transactional** leadership is a contractual exchange — quid pro quo — explained through contingent reward and management by exception (active = micromanaging; passive = intervening only when something goes wrong).

The four skill categories (Lunenburg & Ornstein, 2000)

Administrative Skills — problem analysis, judgment. **Interpersonal Skills** — coaching, sensitivity, stress tolerance. **Communication Skills** — oral, written, and nonverbal communication. **Related Skills** — range of interests, personal motivation, flexibility.

Quick Test — Week Recap

1. Which of Lewin's three styles was found to be most effective, and which was least productive?

   Answer: Participative (Democratic) was most effective; Laissez-Faire (Delegative) was least productive.

2. What's the key difference between Transformational and Transactional leadership?

   Answer: Transformational leadership inspires a shared vision and higher motives; Transactional leadership is a contractual exchange of value between leader and follower.

3. Which skill category do "coaching" and "sensitivity" belong to?

   Answer: Interpersonal Skills.

Week 9 — Decision-Making Models and Styles

The Cognitive Resource Model (Fiedler & Garcia, 1987)

Focuses on how a leader's intelligence and experience interact with stress. Under **low stress**, intelligence contributes to success. Under **high stress**, experience matters more than raw intelligence — in fact, under high stress, intelligence can even make things worse if no rational solution is available. For simple tasks, neither intelligence nor experience matters much.

Vroom and Yetton's Normative Decision Model (1973)

Focuses on how much input subordinates should have. Judged on two criteria: **decision quality** (is it objectively good?) and **decision acceptance** (do followers own it, not just comply?). Five decision-making strategies, from most to least autocratic: A1 (decide alone), A2 (gather info then decide alone), C1 (consult individuals, decide alone), C2 (consult the group, decide alone), G2 (share the problem with the group and decide together).

Rational vs. Incremental decision-making

Rational decision-making weighs all alternatives by cost and benefit and picks the best outcome — thorough, but demanding. **Incremental** decision-making only considers a limited set of alternatives, fine-tuning existing programmes rather than starting from scratch — common in public policy, where full information is rarely available.

Quick Test — Week Recap

1. Under high stress, which matters more to a leader's success: intelligence or experience?

Answer: Experience — the Cognitive Resource Model found intelligence has little relationship to success under high stress, while experience does.

2. What is the difference between decision quality and decision acceptance?

Answer: Decision quality is whether the choice is objectively good; decision acceptance is whether followers genuinely own the decision rather than just complying with it.

3. What does the "G2" decision-making strategy involve?

Answer: The leader shares the problem with the group and invites them to participate fully in making the decision together.

Week 10 — Leading Teams and Crisis Management

Group vs. Team

A **group** is two or more people freely interacting with shared norms, goals, and identity. A **team** is a smaller group with complementary skills who hold themselves *mutually accountable* for a shared purpose — that mutual accountability is the key upgrade from group to team.

Group dynamics

Smaller groups (around 7-9 members) tend to perform best — easier coordination, higher motivation. Large groups risk **social loafing** (individuals exerting less effort collectively than they would alone) and **groupthink** (the desire for harmony overriding good decision-making).

The five stages of team development

Forming (uncertainty, orientation), **Storming** (conflict over roles), **Norming** (cohesion, roles settle), **Performing** (fully functional, trust established), **Adjourning** (wrapping up, closure). Groups can stall or move backward through these stages — moving through them quickly is a sign of a well-led team.

Leading in crisis

A crisis is a specific, unexpected event creating high uncertainty and threat (Seeger et al., 1998). How to lead through one: keep focus and don't panic, communicate openly and often, provide context, set the tone, stay visible, protect company culture, and redefine the "new normal" once it passes.

Quick Test — Week Recap

1. What turns a group into a team?

Answer: Mutual accountability — a team is a small group with complementary skills who hold themselves jointly responsible for shared goals.

2. What is social loafing, and when is it more likely?

Answer: The tendency to put in less effort in a group than working alone — more likely in larger groups where individual contributions are harder to identify.

3. Which stage of team development involves the most conflict, and which one is fully functional?

Answer: Storming has the most conflict; Performing is when the team is fully functional and trusting.

Week 11 — Ethical Leadership and Values

Ethics vs. Morality

"Ethic" comes from the Greek *ethos* — character or accepted moral custom. Ethics is the branch of philosophy that studies morality; morality itself is the set of rules guiding conduct. In short: ethics is the *study* of what morality lays out.

Northouse's 5 principles of ethical leadership

Respect Others — value people's own goals, don't treat them purely as a means to yours. **Serve Others** — act as a steward of the shared vision, not a self-centred one. **Be Just** — put fairness and impartiality at the centre of decisions. **Be Honest** — stay open and authentic, while balancing sensitivity to how the truth lands. **Build Community** — search for goals that work for everyone, not just the leader's own agenda.

Making tough ethical decisions

Hojnacki's (2004) three rules: **The Rule of Private Gain** — are you the only one benefiting, at someone else's expense? **If Everyone Does It** — who gets hurt if this became common practice? **Benefits vs. Burden** — do the benefits actually outweigh the downsides?

Enforcement of ethics and accountability in Ghana

Key institutions: CHRAJ, EOCO, the Economic Crime Court, the Public Accounts Committee, the Auditor-General, and the Office of the Special Prosecutor — the formal system meant to hold public conduct to account.

Quick Test — Week Recap

1. Name any three of Northouse's five principles of ethical leadership.

   Answer: Any three of: Respect Others, Serve Others, Be Just, Be Honest, Build Community.

2. What does "Build Community" mean as an ethical leadership principle?

   Answer: Leaders and followers should search for goals that are compatible with everyone, rather than the leader imposing their own agenda.

3. What question does the "Rule of Private Gain" ask you to consider?

   Answer: Whether you're the only one personally gaining from a decision, and if so, whether that's at someone else's expense — a signal to question your ethics before acting.